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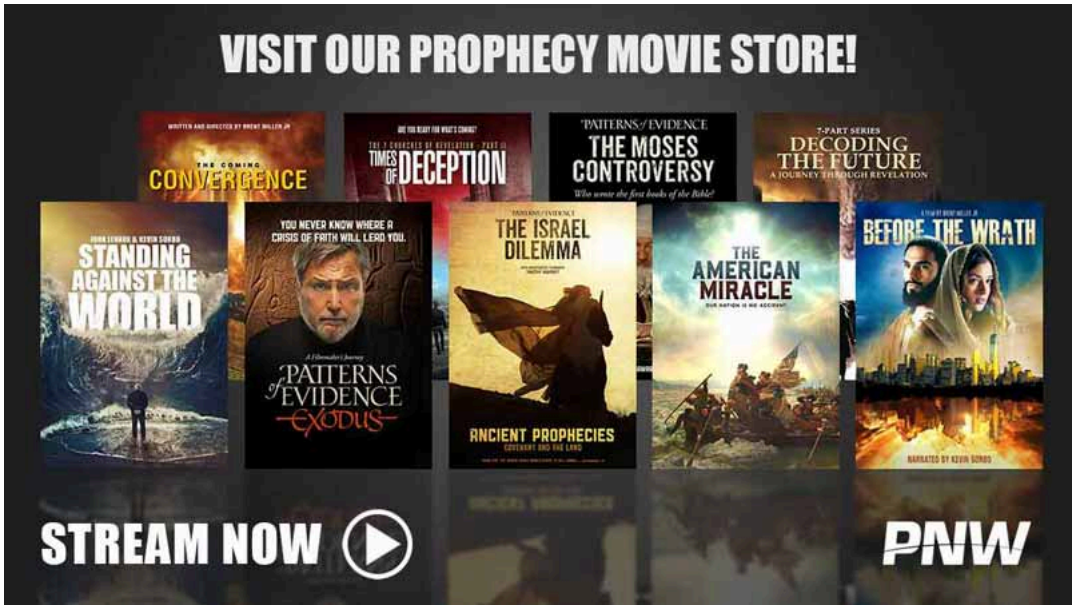

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ARTICLE

Drought, Diesel, And Fertilizer - Global Food Shock Could Be Coming

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Afriq Water

BY PNW STAFF APRIL 15, 2026

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It's not one crisis--it's two, colliding at the worst possible moment. Across the United States and much of the world, farmers are being squeezed by a brutal combination of worsening drought conditions and surging input costs--especially diesel fuel and nitrogen fertilizer. On their own, either challenge would strain the global food system. Together, they form a "double whammy" that could ripple through grocery stores, economies, and households within months.

And the timing couldn't be worse.

Spring planting season is the most critical window of the year for farmers. It's when decisions are made that determine how much food will be available not just this fall--but well into 2027. But this year, many farmers are being forced to make impossible choices.

In parts of the American Midwest and Plains, persistent dryness has already weakened soil conditions. Crops like corn, soybeans, and wheat depend heavily on early moisture to establish strong roots. Without it, yields decline--even before fertilizer or fuel costs are factored in.

But those costs are now front and center.

Following escalating tensions in the Middle East and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz--a chokepoint for global energy and fertilizer shipments--diesel prices have surged, and fertilizer supplies have tightened dramatically. For farmers like Andy Corriher in North Carolina,

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people. When farmers cut back on fertilizer--as many now are--crop yields almost always fall. Corriher has already reduced his fertilizer use by a third. Others are applying only the "bare minimum," hoping to stretch limited supplies.

At the same time, diesel fuel--the lifeblood of farm equipment and transportation--is becoming more expensive and less certain. Tractors don't run without it. Neither do irrigation systems, harvesters, or the trucks that carry food to market.

The result? A slow-motion squeeze on food production.

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Domestically, the U.S. agricultural sector has already been under pressure. Net farm income has been declining for years, while costs continue to rise. Now, with this sudden shock, many farmers are operating on razor-thin margins--or worse. Some are questioning whether they can afford to plant at all.

But the crisis doesn't stop at America's borders.

Half a world away, in Australia, the situation is even more precarious. The country is facing a potential fuel emergency that could bring both transportation and agriculture to a standstill. With only about 38 days of petrol, 31 days of diesel, and 28 days of jet fuel in reserve, officials are warning that rationing may soon be unavoidable if supply lines are not restored.

For a nation that is the world's fifth-largest producer of wheat and second-largest exporter of barley, the implications are enormous.

If Australian farmers cannot access the diesel needed to plant and harvest crops, global grain supplies could take a significant hit. Wheat and barley are staple commodities, feeding millions directly and indirectly through livestock production. A disruption in Australia doesn't stay in Australia--it reverberates through global markets.

And Australia is not alone.

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The Strait of Hormuz is one of the most critical arteries in the global supply chain. A prolonged closure doesn't just impact oil prices--it chokes off the flow of essential agricultural inputs to farmers around the world.

If that closure continues, the consequences 6 to 9 months from now could be severe.

Lower fertilizer use today means smaller harvests tomorrow. Smaller harvests lead to tighter supplies, higher prices, and increased risk of shortages--especially in vulnerable regions that depend heavily on imports.

In practical terms, that could mean significantly higher grocery bills for American families by late 2026. It could also mean food insecurity worsening in developing nations, where even small price increases can push millions into hunger.

And there's another layer to this crisis that often goes unnoticed: transportation.

Even if crops are successfully grown, they still need to be moved. Diesel shortages don't just impact farmers--they impact truckers, shipping companies, and the entire logistics network. In Australia, trucking leaders are already warning that without fuel, the industry could grind to a halt. The same risk, on a smaller scale, exists elsewhere.

Food doesn't just grow--it moves. And right now, both processes are under threat.

Looking ahead, the next six months will be critical. If the Strait of Hormuz reopens and supply chains stabilize, some of the worst-case scenarios may be avoided. But if disruptions persist, the world could be staring down a significant food supply shock--one that builds quietly over time before hitting suddenly at the checkout line.

This is not a distant or abstract issue. It's a chain reaction already in motion--from dry soil in American fields to fuel shortages in Australia, from fertilizer plants in the Middle East to grocery shelves across the globe.

The warning signs are there.

The question now is whether the world is paying attention before the harvest comes up short.

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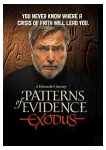

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